

Aalto Executive MBA in Seoul, Helsinki Residence Program 2026

Track: Entrepreneurship Rethinking Business

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Professor Sanna-Katriina Asikainen's research and teaching covers topics related to Strategic Management, International Marketing, and International Entrepreneurship, and she has published in scholarly journals, like Journal of the Academy of Marketing Science, Journal of Business Research, International Marketing Review, Journal of World Business, Industrial Marketing Management, and European Journal of Marketing.

Sanna-Katriina Asikainen is Associate Professor in Marketing at Aalto University, School of Business. Prior joining Aalto she worked as Professor of International Marketing at School of Business and Management, Lappeenranta University of Technology, Finland, 2002-2020. In the past, she has worked as a visiting scholar at Scancor, Stanford University, US, and as a visiting professor at Loughborough University, School of Business and Economics, UK.

Professor Asikainen has received many awards and honors for her research: Her article "Measuring inter-organizational trust-a critical review of the empirical research in 1990-2003" was nominated as the Top 25 Hottest Articles in Industrial Marketing Management. Her teaching has been awarded the 'Teaching achievement' of the year 2013, by the Finnish Association of Business School Graduates (SEFE). Sanna-Katriina Asikainen holds a Doctor of Science Technology from Lappeenranta University of Technology.

Class Dates

Weekday	Date	Local Time
Wednesday	August 5, 2026	08.30 –16.30
Thursday	August 6, 2026	08.30 –16.30
Friday	August 7, 2026	08.30 –16.30

Venue

The module is held at Aalto EE's premises, located on Runeberginkatu 14-16, 00100 Helsinki Finland

Deadlines

Task	Date	Submission
Pre-Assignment	July 20, 2026, by 10.00 KST	Aalto Canvas

Module Overview

No firm today can confidently assume it will be immune to dramatic shifts in its competitive environment. The question is not whether to renew, but how and who drives renewal.

This module takes the entrepreneurial mindset you have developed and asks a difficult question: how do established firms deploy it? We examine renewal as a strategic and managerial challenge i.e., the decisions, capabilities, and leadership behaviors that determine whether large firms can transform themselves before the market forces them to. We look at firms that succeeded and firms that did not.

Innovations are the mechanisms through which firms transform the value they create for customers, stakeholders, and society. But innovation in established organizations is embedded in contexts that can either enable or suffocate it. Understanding those contexts and learning to shape them is the central leadership challenge this module addresses.

Key Theories and Concepts of the Module

Market creation, innovations, disruption, business models, capabilities, intrapreneurship, learning, and cognition.

Module Objectives

- *Diagnose why established firms struggle to renew even when they have the resources, awareness, and tools to do so by understanding the role of organizational inertia, managerial cognition, and capability traps.*
- *Distinguish between types of innovation and renewal strategies (incremental, disruptive, business model).*
- *Analyze how firms build, extend, and reconfigure capabilities over time to sustain competitive advantage.*
- *Evaluate the role of leadership and managerial decision-making in enabling or impeding renewal, and identify the specific behaviors and practices that drive transformation in established organizations.*
- *Apply strategic renewal frameworks, like diagnosing current challenges and identifying actionable pathways for renewal.*

Teaching Methods and Materials

This module is designed to be at the heart of entrepreneurial business renewal – in other words, the focus will be on a selected set of key strategic concepts and theories managers need to master. This course is based on **discussion-based teaching and learning via reflections in class** (based on work done prior to the class meetings) and thus the style of the module's sessions is **highly interactive**. Participants are expected to participate actively in the discussion and the case presentations.

Mandatory Pre-readings (also used in-class)

Articles/Cases

The following three cases are used as the basis for your reflection in your written pre-assignment. Read the pre-assignment instructions first and then start your reading assignment by reading the cases below. Note cases provide a lot of information and thus it is recommended

to read them multiple times. Note, that these cases are also used in class as the basis for case analysis and the related class discussions during the module. Thus, you are expected to have read them and be prepared to join the case analysis discussion during the module. All pre-reading materials are available in Canvas.

For August 5th

1. Ryan L. Raffaelli and Christine Snively (2018). "Reinvention of Kodak". Harvard Business School Case 419012, November 2018.

For August 6th

2. Rivkin, Jan W., Thomke, Stefan and Daniela Beyersdorfer (2012) "LEGO". Harvard Business School Case 613004, July 2012.

For August 7th

1. Montgomery, Cynthia A. and Max Hancock (2023) "BYD, China, and Global Electric Vehicle Rivalry" Harvard Business School Case 724358, August 2023.

Assignments

Pre-assignment

Reflection paper

Write a short essay (max. 2 pages) covering your answers for the questions listed below. In addition, related to module's topic and content, tell us what the focal issues are you are looking answers for from this module.

For this module, you are asked to read the three cases and answer the following questions presented below in your reflection paper:

- Ryan L. Raffaelli and Christine Snively (2018). "Reinvention of Kodak". Harvard Business School Case 419012, November 2018.
 - o What are the leadership challenges facing Clarke as he attempts to bring Kodak out of bankruptcy?
 - o Think also: What leadership challenges you are facing or witnessing at your company that may prevent your company from changing?
- Rivkin, Jan W., Thomke, Stefan and Daniela Beyersdorfer (2012) "LEGO". Harvard Business School Case 613004, July 2012.
 - o What led the LEGO group to the edge of bankruptcy (by 2004)?
 - o Think also: Looking at your company's current portfolio of activities, initiatives, and investments, which ones genuinely strengthen your core competitive advantage, and which ones are consuming resources while pulling you away from it? What prevents your leadership from making that distinction clearly?
- Montgomery, Cynthia A. and Max Hancock (2023) "BYD, China, and Global Electric Vehicle Rivalry" Harvard Business School Case 724358, August 2023.
 - o How BYD built a sequence of capabilities over 20 years that created an entrenched competitive advantage? Which strategic moves were most decisive?
 - o Think also: What are your company's/unit's critical capabilities that (a) give your firm a sustained competitive advantage and (b) help you to renew?

Please submit your written pre-assignment to Aalto Canvas on July 20 by 10.00 KST at the latest. Kindly note that late submission will drastically affect your grade.

In-class Assignments

Case discussions and small assignments based on these three cases. Participants will be formed into teams and asked to prepare for the case presentations.

Final Examination

The final examination is an individual assignment that will be published online in Aalto Canvas after the module. Participants have until **Tuesday August 11, 2026, 10.00 KST** to work on the examination. The examination will be a so-called open book where use of all material is allowed. However, the examination is to be done individually and given AI instructions must be respected.

Kindly submit your take-home assignment in Canvas by Tue 11th of August by 10.00 KST at the latest. Please note that late submission will drastically affect your grade.

Assessment and Grading

Components of Course Grade

Your final grade will be calculated on the following basis:

- | | |
|---------------------------------|-----|
| • Pre-assignment | 20% |
| • Individual class contribution | 10% |
| • In-Class group assignments | 30% |
| • Final examination | 40% |

Evaluation of the Pre-assignment

An excellent grade will be given to those who show that they can relate the ideas in the cases and also reflect case topics to their own working life.

Evaluation of Individual Class Participation

A participant is expected to demonstrate strong learning engagement by showing consistent preparation, active attention, and meaningful participation throughout the course.

Evaluation of In-Class Group Assignments

We will be doing many assignments also in groups, and it is therefore vital, in order to achieve a high grade, that the student commits fully to the group they are working with. After each group assignment, there will be a presentation of the output, and these will be taken into consideration as part of the grading.

Evaluation of Final Examination

The final examination will call on the student to apply the theory and learnings from the class to a case/problem/question. High grades will be achieved by those students who manage to apply the appropriate theoretical learnings to the relevant parts of the case/problem and to make sensible recommendations.

Grading

Please note that in order to pass the final exam student should get at least 50% of the required marks. One re-attempt is allowed in case of failing (F). All grades are final. If a participant has passed the

module with the lowest possible grade or higher, no retakes of any of the assignments are allowed in hopes of improving the grade.

Class Attendance

Class attendance is critical. Local EMBA Team must be informed in advance via email of any missed segments; otherwise, class attendance is regarded as mandatory. In case of a sudden situation, the notification must be sent as soon as possible, even after the absence. Absences exceeding a certain limit (see below) will affect the module grade negatively.

Three possible outcomes may follow due to an absence:

- No effect on final module grade for a maximum absence of 3,5 hours in Aalto Executive MBA
- Downgrading the final module grade by 5 points for an absence of >3,5–6 hours in Aalto Executive MBA
- Downgrading the final module grade by 10 points for an absence of >6–8 hours in Aalto Executive MBA reason for such an absence must be exceptional.

All absences during the module days count towards the total amount of absence hour. Absences exceeding 8 hours or one full module day in the Aalto Executive MBA are not allowed.

Aalto University official policy on use of AI in teaching and learning (amended for Aalto EE use)

Advanced language models, such as ChatGPT and other models that generate images, videos, and audio, have reached a level where their produced content can be difficult to distinguish from human-generated content. Software and services based on artificial intelligence are expected to continue to develop and increase in the future, and so their use should also be considered in teaching and research. In this text, the term artificial intelligence refers to software and services that utilise AI, of which currently the best-known examples include ChatGPT, Claude, Copilot, Gemini, DeepL, Dall-e, Bard, Midjourney, and grammar aids used in text processing software.

1. The use of AI-based technologies is allowed as a support for teaching and learning unless instructed otherwise by the instructor of the course. The instructor of the course may decide on restrictions on the use of technology on a course- or task-specific basis if achieving the learning objectives of the course requires it. • **If the instructor decides to restrict the use of AI on a course- or task-specific basis**, they must provide clear instructions on the limitations in connection with the assessment criteria and time the guidance so that the participant has the possibility to complete the task as instructed. The instructor may ask the participant to describe how AI has been used in the learning task.

2. The participant is always responsible for the content of their submitted work. • For example, language models can be used for formatting or ideation of the text produced, unless otherwise instructed by the instructor. However, AI-generated text cannot be presented as is as the participant's own written response. The participant is obligated to follow academic writing practices (e.g. cite AI produced text like any other source: "OpenAI. (2023). *ChatGPT* (Mar 14 version) [Large language model]"). Upon the instructor's request, the participant is obligated to describe how, what and/or why AI-based technology has been used to do the learning task.

3. Utilizing AI in a learning task contrary to the instructor's instructions will be considered cheating and will be handled in accordance with the current procedures. • The official text-

plagiarism detection tool Turnitin used by Aalto University has a tool for instructors that identifies text produced by AI. By using this system, the instructor has the opportunity to assess whether a language model has been used to produce the text.

*Participants must **request permission from the instructor** before recording any lecture or session (including audio, video, or screen capture).*

Additional information

Kindly note that the schedule below comprises only the schedule for the module days. Information of the possible extracurricular activities, such as Aalto greetings event and a campus visit, will be announced separately.

Module Schedule

Each day includes a lunch break. Additional breaks will be held flexibly throughout the days.

Wednesday, August 5, 2026 08:30 – 16:30

Understanding the Need for Innovation and Renewal

08:30 – 08:40 Welcome words from Program Team

08:40 – 11:45 Roots to Strategic Renewal

11:45 – 12:45 Lunch (time is an estimate)

12:45 – 16:30 Types of Innovations and Renewal

Thursday, August 6, 2026, 08:30 – 16:30

Making the Renewal

08:30 – 11:45 Trying to Become a Different Type of Company

11:45 – 12:45 Lunch (time is an estimate)

12:45 – 16:30 The Art of Strategic Renewal

Friday, August 7, 2026, 08:30 – 16:30

Creating and Responding to Disruption

08:30 – 11:45 Business Model (Innovations)

11:45 – 12:45 Lunch (time is an estimate)

12.45 – 16.30 Shifting Gears in Disruptive Times

Program Team Corner



Welcome to your third module of your Helsinki Residence Program and the Entrepreneurship track. We'll enjoy the teachings of Dr. Sanna-Katriina Asikainen in her module called Rethinking Business.

This module will be very intensive and hands-on so we hope you will take the time to prepare well and will be ready to actively contribute to group work and interactive discussions in class.

Looking forward to meeting you all in Helsinki!

Sincerely,
Andreea and your EMBA team for the Helsinki Residence Program

Contact Information

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